In the world, there is change, there is a temporal structure of relations between events that is anything but illusory. It is not a global happening. It is a local and complex one that is not amenable to being described in terms of a single global order.

And what about Einstein's phrase "the distinction between past, present and future is only a stubbornly persistent illusion"? Does it not seem to say that he thought the opposite?

Even if this were the case, I am not sure that because Einstein has penned some phrase or other we should treat is as the utterance of an oracle. Einstein changed his mind many times on fundamental questions, and it is possible to find numerous erroneous phrases of his that contradict each other.[66] But in this instance, things are perhaps much simpler. Or more profound.

Einstein coins this phrase when his friend Michele Besso dies. Michele has been his dearest friend, the companion of his thinking and discussions since his days at the University of Zurich. The letter in which Einstein writes the phrase is not directed at physicists or philosophers. It is addressed to Michele's family, and in particular to his sister. The sentence that comes before it reads:

> Now he [Michele] has departed from this strange world a little ahead of me. That means nothing. . . .

It is not a letter written to pontificate about the structure of the world, it's a letter written to console a grieving sister. A gentle letter, alluding to the spiritual bond between Michele and Albert. A letter in which Einstein also confronts his own suffering at the loss of his lifelong friend; and in which, evidently, he is thinking about his own approaching death. A deeply emotional letter, in which the illusoriness and the heartrending irrelevance to which he alludes do not refer to time as understood by physicists. They are prompted by the experience of life itself. Fragile, brief, full of illusions. It's a phrase that speaks of things that lie deeper than the *physical* nature of time.

Einstein died on April 18, 1955, one month and three days after the death of his friend.